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Subtraction tricks — Numbers 45 to 53

Each passage is now a mini-lesson: a challenge to hook them in, the trick, one worked example, two for the child to try, then both checked together — with encouragement all the way through. Read it like you're at the kitchen table and someone just asked "go on then, show me".

The four rules

1. Before each passage say its number clearly — "Number one", "Number two" — pause a second, read the passage, then pause a couple of seconds before the next number. Those gaps are how I find the joins. 2. Wherever you see ... leave a short beat — two seconds is plenty. Those are the "have a think" moments for the kids. 3. If you stumble, don't stop the recording: pause, say the SAME number again, and read that passage again. I'll keep your retake. 4. Kitchen-table warmth beats newsreader polish every time.

Total is roughly two hours of reading — absolutely fine to do over several sittings (each take just needs to start at a numbered item; tick them off on the printed version as you go). When done, drop the audio file(s) — m4a, mp3, wav, anything — into OneDrive Times tables/recordings and tell me.

Tick each number as you record it so you can pick up where you left off.

Part C — Subtraction tricks

■ Say: "Number 45" — Take Away in Parts

Quick one — what's 56 minus 23? ... If that came to you in under ten seconds, you're already thinking like a maths whizz. If not, don't worry a bit — this trick sorts it out. It's called Take Away in Parts. Instead of subtracting the whole number in one scary go, take away the big part first — the tens — then the small part, the ones. Watch with 56 minus 23. First take away the 20: 56 minus 20 is 36. Now take away the 3: 36 minus 3 is 33. So 56 minus 23 is 33. Two gentle steps instead of one hard one. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 78 minus 45? ... and what's 87 minus 34? ... Have a proper go before I tell you ... Let's check together. 78 minus 45: take away the 40 first — 78 minus 40 is 38. Then take away the 5: 38 minus 5 is 33. So 78 minus 45 is 33. And 87 minus 34: take away the 30 — 87 minus 30 is 57. Then the 4: 57 minus 4 is 53. So 87 minus 34 is 53. See? You've got this one — go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 46" — Count Back

Quick one — what's 52 minus 3? ... If that popped out in a couple of seconds, brilliant, you've already got this trick. If you had to think hard, stick with me — it takes about a minute to learn. When you're taking away just 1, 2 or 3, don't do any working out at all. Just count backwards, one little step at a time. Three small hops back beats one big sum every time. Watch it with 52 minus 3. Start at 52 and step back three times: 51 ... 50 ... 49. That's it — 52 minus 3 is 49. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 74 minus 2? ... and what's 61 minus 3? ... Have a proper go before I tell you... Right, let's check together. 74 minus 2: start at 74 and hop back twice — 73 ... 72. So 74 minus 2 is 72. Now 61 minus 3: start at 61 and take three steps back — 60 ... 59 ... 58. So 61 minus 3 is 58. See? You've got this one — quick little steps back, and off you go to the practice.

■ Say: "Number 47" — Count Up

Try this one on for size — what's 42 minus 38? ... If you got it in under ten seconds, you're already thinking like a maths whizz. If not, no stress — this trick makes it easy. When the two numbers are close together, don't count backwards at all. Count UP from the smaller number to the bigger one, and count how many steps it takes. That number of steps is your answer. Let's do 42 minus 38. Start at 38 and climb: 39, 40, 41, 42. That took 4 steps, so 42 minus 38 is 4. So much friendlier than counting back 38! Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 71 minus 66? ... and what's 53 minus 49? ... Have a real go before I spill the answers... Let's check them together. 71 minus 66: start at 66 and count up — 67, 68, 69, 70, 71. That's 5 steps, so 71 minus 66 is 5. And 53 minus 49: start at 49 — 50, 51, 52, 53. That's 4 steps, so 53 minus 49 is 4. That's it — when the numbers are close, climb up instead of falling back. Go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 48" — Bridge Down

Here's a quick one — what's 43 minus 8? ... Got it in a flash? Then you're already bridging like a pro. Took a bit longer? Perfect — this trick is exactly for you. It's called Bridge Down, and the idea is simple: step down onto the nearest ten first, because tens are lovely to work from. Split the number you're taking away into two friendly bits. Watch with 43 minus 8. How many gets you from 43 down to 40? That's 3. So split the 8 into 3 plus 5. First jump: 43 minus 3 is 40. Second jump: 40 minus 5 is 35. So 43 minus 8 is 35. Two easy hops with a ten in the middle. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 62 minus 5? ... and what's 34 minus 6? ... Have a proper go first... Let's check together. 62 minus 5: from 62 down to 60 is 2, so split 5 into 2 plus 3. 62 minus 2 is 60, then 60 minus 3 is 57. And 34 minus 6: from 34 down to 30 is 4, so split 6 into 4 plus 2. 34 minus 4 is 30, then 30 minus 2 is 28. See? Land on the ten and the rest is easy — you've got this one.

■ Say: "Number 49" — Think Addition

Quick fire — what's 14 minus 9? ... Under ten seconds? You're flying. Longer? No worries at all — here's a sneaky way to make it easy. The secret is that every subtraction is really an addition wearing a disguise. Instead of taking away, flip the question round and ask what you'd need to ADD. You already know loads of addition facts, so let them do the work. So for 14 minus 9, ask it the other way: 9 plus what makes 14? Think... 9 plus 5 is 14. So 14 minus 9 is 5. No counting back, no fuss — just an addition fact you already knew, flipped over. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 13 minus 7? ... and what's 16 minus 8? ... Have a proper think before I tell you... Let's check them together. 13 minus 7 — flip it: 7 plus what makes 13? 7 plus 6 is 13, so 13 minus 7 is 6. And 16 minus 8 — flip it: 8 plus what makes 16? That's a double you know: 8 plus 8 is 16, so 16 minus 8 is 8. That's it — you now know a trick most grown-ups never spot. Go show the practice who's boss.

■ Say: "Number 50" — Round and Adjust

Here's a challenge — what's 62 minus 29? ... If you cracked that in under ten seconds, hats off, you probably already use this trick. If it felt awkward, that's the 29's fault, and we're about to fix it. The trick is Round and Adjust: round the number you're taking away to something tidy, do the easy sum, then fix it afterwards. Watch with 62 minus 29. That 29 is nearly 30, so round it up to 30. Now the easy bit: 62 minus 30 is 32. But hang on — we took away 1 too many, so give 1 back: 32 plus 1 is 33. So 62 minus 29 is 33. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 84 minus 38? ... and what's 71 minus 19? ... Have a proper go before I tell you... Let's check together. 84 minus 38: round 38 up to 40. 84 minus 40 is 44. We took 2 too many, so add 2 back: 44 plus 2 is 46. And 71 minus 19: round 19 up to 20. 71 minus 20 is 51. Give 1 back: 51 plus 1 is 52. See? Messy numbers turned tidy — you've absolutely got this one.

■ Say: "Number 51" — Same Difference

Quick one — what's 74 minus 37? ... If that came out smoothly in a few seconds, you might already know today's trick. If your brain went "urgh", perfect — this will change everything. It's called Same Difference, and here's the magic: the gap between two numbers doesn't change if you slide BOTH numbers up by the same amount. So slide them until the sum turns tidy. Watch with 74 minus 37. Add 3 to both numbers: 74 becomes 77, and 37 becomes 40. Now it's 77 minus 40, which is 37. So 74 minus 37 is 37. Same gap, much friendlier numbers. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 82 minus 58? ... and what's 53 minus 27? ... Have a proper go before I give the game away... Let's check together. 82 minus 58: add 2 to both, so it becomes 84 minus 60. That's 24, so 82 minus 58 is 24. And 53 minus 27: add 3 to both, so it becomes 56 minus 30. That's 26, so 53 minus 27 is 26. See? Slide both numbers, keep the gap — you now know a trick most grown-ups don't. Off you go.

■ Say: "Number 52" — Subtract from 100

Challenge time — what's 100 minus 42? ... If you fired that back in under ten seconds, you already think in pairs that make 100. If not, this trick is a beauty. To subtract from 100, don't subtract at all — find the partner that pairs up with your number to make 100. And here's the shortcut: if the number doesn't end in 0, the ones digits add to 10 and the tens digits add to 9. Watch with 100 minus 42. Ones digit is 2, and 2 needs 8 to make 10. Tens digit is 4, and 4 needs 5 to make 9. So the partner is 58 — and 100 minus 42 is 58. Check it: 42 plus 58 is 100. Lovely. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 100 minus 76? ... and what's 100 minus 30? ... Have a proper go first... Let's check together. 100 minus 76: ones — 6 needs 4 to make 10. Tens — 7 needs 2 to make 9. So the answer is 24. And 100 minus 30 ends in 0, so just use tens bonds: 3 plus 7 is 10, so the answer is 70. See? Ones to 10, tens to 9 — you've got this one. Go smash the practice.

■ Say: "Number 53" — Subtract 9 and 99

Quick one — what's 45 minus 9? ... Under ten seconds and you're already ahead of the game. Took longer? No bother — this trick makes 9s a doddle forever. Here's the idea: taking away 9 is nearly the same as taking away 10, and 10 is easy. So take away 10, then give 1 back, because you took 1 too many. Watch with 45 minus 9. Take away 10: 45 minus 10 is 35. Now give 1 back: 35 plus 1 is 36. So 45 minus 9 is 36. And it works for 99 too — take away 100, then give 1 back. Your turn — pause me if you need to: what's 72 minus 9? ... and here's a big one: what's 431 minus 99? ... Have a proper go before I tell you... Let's check together. 72 minus 9: take away 10 to get 62, then give 1 back — 63. So 72 minus 9 is 63. And 431 minus 99: take away 100 to get 331, then give 1 back — 332. So 431 minus 99 is 332. See? Even a big scary sum falls over with this one — go show the practice what you can do.

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